Sabha seats from the state will be by no means an easy task. Other than the JD(U), the NDA in Bihar includes smaller caste-based parties, which, too, will demand their pound of flesh. And each of them is enmeshed in a history of friction.

A key NDA ally from 2019, the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) of the late Ram Vilas Paswan, has now split—with the LJP (Ram Vilas) led by his son and Jamui MP Chirag Paswan and the Rashtriya LJP led by Hajipur MP and Chirag's uncle Pashupati Kumar Paras scrambling to claim the six LJP seats. And Nitish and Chirag have no love lost for each other and the triangle they form with the BJP is fraught with perilous memories. By all accounts, Chirag was the very knife-edge the BJP used to slice Nitish down to 40-odd seats during the 2020 assembly polls—fielded as a wild card in seats the JD(U) was contesting so as to cut votes. Considering that's how their last alliance bled to an early demise, no one's expecting the trio to have a cosy cohabitation.

If Nitish got a whiff of perfidy then, there's plenty of it in the air even now—certainly on the tongues of bazaar soothsayers. That's why, though JD(U) leaders haven't spoken about it, RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav has been repeatedly alleging that Nitish's plan is to hold assembly polls simultaneously with the Lok Sabha election. Otherwise due only in 2025, Nitish's hope is said to be to milk maximum benefits out of the momentum the NDA gets out of a general election so as to secure another term and extend his own political life-span. But if a promise on this formed the basis of the new friendship contract, the BJP has betrayed no signs of it.

On the contrary, its moves have the potential to fill Nitish with some foreboding. Silently, the BJP has been activating its playbook from other states in Bihar. Some seven Opposition MLAs, five from the RJD and two from the Congress, have been sitting with the treasury benches in the past three weeks. Though the seven turncoats have not officially joined the BJP, it has for all practical purposes swelled the BJP numbers to 85 in the 243-strong Bihar assembly. An en bloc shift of another dozen or so Congress MLAs, as the word on the street has it, can both stave off the long arm of the anti-defection law and take the BJP—ominously enough for Nitish—within striking distance of a solo bid for power. That's why, though the BJP's central leadership has made the state unit accept Nitish again in a leadership role for the Lok Sabha polls, they may not be so keen on simultaneous polls. They simply might not need it.

The intent is certainly there. In fact, on February 8, just 10 days after taking over as deputy CM in the new government, BJP state president Samrat Choudhary said as much. "Today, we're working with the NDA, but make no mistake: we'll have a BJP regime in Bihar one day)," Samrat told party workers in Patna. A senior BJP leader says the party feels that day is near, and a post-Nitish future is what it foresees after the next assembly polls. So, for Nitish, the task is an onerous one: and it's not just about having to consort with Chirag. Or other troublesome NDA constituents like Upendra Kushwaha of the Rashtriya Lok Janata Dal and Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular)—neither a sworn friend of either Nitish or the BJP, both in for transactional reasons.

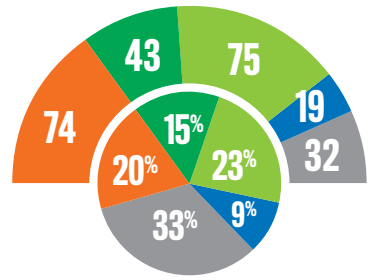
Meanwhile, it suits everyone to hang together for now. A senior BJP leader lists multiple reasons for backing Nitish one more time, but concedes: "Beyond the Lok Sabha polls, it's unlikely the party will find any use for the alliance." As of now, Bihar is the only state besides Maharashtra where the BJP, despite being part of the government, does not lead it. They may need alliance partner JD(U) for one more national campaign to take as many seats of the state's 40 Lok Sabha seats as they can. All bets are off after that. ■

THE SAFFRON SPREAD

The BJP has overtaken the JD(U) to become part of the top two in Bihar

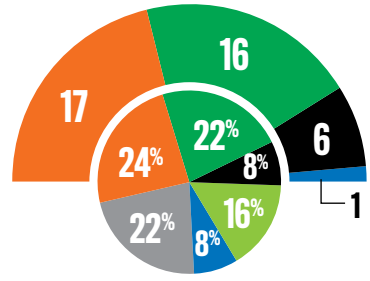
2020 ASSEMBLY

Share of seats (243) and votes



2019 LOK SABHA

Share of seats (40) and votes



BJP JD(U) LJP
RJD INC Others

THE BJP MAY HAVE ALLOWED NITISH TO LEAD THE NDA IN BIHAR FOR THE GENERAL ELECTION, BUT ALL BETS ARE OFF AFTER THAT